

ATTITUDES OF CHRISTMAS

TEXT: Luke 1:26- *“Now in the sixth month the angel Gabriel was sent by God to a city of Galilee named Nazareth, 27 to a virgin betrothed to a man whose name was Joseph, of the house of David. The virgin’s name was Mary. 28 And having come in, the angel said to her, “Rejoice, highly favored one, the Lord is with you; blessed are you among women!” 29 But when she saw him, she was troubled at his saying, and considered what manner of greeting this was. 30 Then the angel said to her, “Do not be afraid, Mary, for you have found favor with God. 31 And behold, you will conceive in your womb and bring forth a Son, and shall call His name Jesus. 32 He will be great, and will be called the Son of the Highest; and the Lord God will give Him the throne of His father David. 33 And He will reign over the house of Jacob forever, and of His kingdom there*

will be no end.” 34 Then Mary said to the angel, “How can this be, since I do not know a man?” 35 And the angel answered and said to her, “The Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Highest will overshadow you; therefore, also, that Holy One who is to be born will be called the Son of God. 36 Now indeed, Elizabeth your relative has also conceived a son in her old age; and this is now the sixth month for her who was called barren. 37 For with God nothing will be impossible.” 38 Then Mary said, “Behold the maidservant of the Lord! Let it be to me according to your word.” And the angel departed from her.”

ONTRO: Today I want to look at some of the actors in the Christmas narrative and learn from their reactions what kind of attitude we should exhibit as we walk through this Christmas season.

There are those who had good attitudes and those who had bad attitudes. The ones who displayed good attitudes have gone down in history as having made a difference. The ones who acted with indifference are nothing more than an ancient, archaic, historical figure.

The attitude with which they reacted to the announcement of the birth of Christ prepositioned them to be a participant or a resistor of God's plan. The same is true of us, our attitudes have much to do with determining how far or fast we can go, or whether we can go at all!

I want to look at those who had good attitudes in this story.

Remember, our attitudes are a reflection of our hearts. When we stand in front of a full length mirror, the mirror don't lie! When we are put under pressure our attitude is a

reflection of our heart - the mirror doesn't lie!

- If our hearts are in the right place, our attitudes will be right...
- If our hearts are in the wrong place, our attitudes will be wrong...
- If our attitudes are right, God can utilize us for his purpose...
- If our attitudes are wrong, God cannot use us for His purposes...

I. MARY HAD THE ATTITUDE OF A SERVANT...

Think of this... Mary had her life planned out:

- She was engaged to the hunk Joseph...
- She planned for the house and white picket fence...
- She and Joseph would have 2.5 children...
- Joseph would have a successful carpentry business and provide for Mary

and the children...

- She and Joseph would have grandchildren and grow old together...
...And they would live happily ever after...

Mary's plans were about to be interrupted in the most cataclysmic way possible! The angel announced to her that God had plans that differed from hers! Luke 1:31-33 ***“And behold, you will conceive in your womb and bring forth a Son, and shall call His name Jesus. 32 He will be great, and will be called the Son of the Highest; and the Lord God will give Him the throne of His father David. 33 And He will reign over the house of Jacob forever, and of His kingdom there will be no end.”***

We know Mary's heart was right by looking at its reflection in her attitude! Luke 1:34 (NKJV) ***“How can this be, since I do not know a man?”*** Pretty normal response; right? Yes, but listen to what follows...

Luke 1:38 (NKJV) *“Then Mary said, “Behold the maidservant of the Lord! Let it be to me according to your word.” And the angel departed from her.”*

Let me ask you, can your attitude stand the onslaught of a mid-course adjustment? Trust me, mid-course adjustments are standard operating procedures! (SOP’s)

We must train our heart to accept God’s will and his timing so that our attitude can reflect what’s best about our hearts!

II. JOSEPH HAD AN ATTITUDE OF RIGHTEOUSNESS...

The word righteousness simply means *“Living in the state of doing the right thing.”* We should be striving every day to live with the attitude of doing the right thing.

You think Mary had something to deal with?

- Joseph loved Mary more than life itself...
- He engaged her to be his companion for life...
- He trusted that her love for him was as great as his love for her...
- The announcement of her pregnancy could only mean one thing – She had been immoral...

Notice this – even before the angel appeared to Joseph the Bible say’s “***Joseph, not wanting to make a public spectacle of Mary decided to end the engagement privately.***”

What a guy! Who wouldn’t want to be married to a dude like that?

The reason Joseph took the action that he did toward Mary - even when he thought the worst - is because his heart was right, and it manifested itself in his attitude!

There is a big difference in the roads we

decide to take:

- We can take the hurtful road...
(Revenge)
- We can take the nonchalant road... (You can't hurt me because I don't care)
- We can take the high road... (Decide not to be mean spirited)
- We can take the highest road... (Forgive and forget – I mean release)

Even before Joseph received a visit from the angel he decided to do Mary no harm!

Then the angel visits. Matthew 1:20 (NKJV)

“While he thought about these things, behold, an angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream, saying, “Joseph, son of David, do not be afraid to take to you Mary your wife, for that which is conceived in her is of the Holy Spirit.”

Without one word of argument Joseph decided to do three things:

- Take Mary to be his wife...

- Refrain from sexual relations with his wife for almost a year...
- Become the earthly father of Jesus...

We should be pursuing a righteous attitude –
Living in the state of doing the right thing!

III. THE MAGI HAD AN ATTITUDE OF WORSHIP...

Matthew 2:1-2 (NKJV) *“Now after Jesus was born in Bethlehem of Judea in the days of Herod the king, behold, wise men from the East came to Jerusalem, 2 saying, “Where is He who has been born King of the Jews? For we have seen His star in the East and have come to worship Him.”*

These wise men came from the East,
probably from what is modern day Iran.

They probably traveled in excess of 1,000 miles by camel to get there. This would have taken several months in hostile conditions.

But they had seen the star!

They did not come because they were being required to, they were there because their hearts told them to, and their attitudes reflected it!

The genealogy of the wise men from Persia can be traced back to the time of Daniel. They specialized in astrology, medicine and natural science. Their visit occurred when Jesus was between 40 days and 2 years old.

The importance of this story is that:

- Jesus is worthy of royal honor from all humanity. Gentiles as well as Jews are included in God's redemptive plan.
- The Jews through their exile may very well have influenced Babylonian and Persian thought, and there are evidences that the people of the East were expecting a world deliverer to appear in

the West - who would usher in a golden era of world peace.

The Babe of Bethlehem had a magnetism that drew the Magi across more than a thousand miles of hostile terrain. In making this trip they also placed their lives in danger to robbers, thugs and hardened criminals. They were carrying very costly gifts that made them vulnerable to a criminal element!

These wise men were not to be dissuaded; they were on a mission to worship this new-born king! What are we willing to risk to develop a heart of worship that can be reflected in an attitude of worship?

The Magi were worshippers – They had an attitude of worship! They did not come empty-handed, they brought gifts fit for a king:

- Gold... They probably brought all kinds of golden gifts and ornaments. Gold is

the only metal that cannot be tarnished by fire! Our worship is the only thing that can get us through the fire – It got the three Hebrew Children through, and it will surely get us through! If we are true worshippers we have had to worship our way through our fair share of fires! Song - *“Some through the fire, some through the flood, some through great trials but all through the blood.”*

- Frankincense... Frankincense was gathered by making an incision into the trunk of the balsam tree. It was an ingredient in the perfume for the most holy place according to Exodus 30:34-38. Frankincense made the offerings smell sweet in the most Holy place and also made the smell of sacrifice acceptable to God. What kind of smell is our worship creating? If we worship with a bad attitude we are stinking the place up! If we are worshipping with a good attitude we are creating a sweet

aroma in the presence of God and others!

- Myrrh... Myrrh oozes from a shrub-like tree in the Middle East. The pale yellow liquid gradually solidifies. Myrrh was sold as a spice or medicine. It was used as an ingredient in anointing oil. It was used as a perfume. It was placed in clothes to deodorize them. And it was used to embalm bodies. We should wear a good attitude – Live in the state of doing the right thing!

CONCLUSION:

An attitude of worship is a reflection of a grateful heart! If ones heart is filled with gratitude one cannot help but return thanks!

If ones heart is filled with ingratitude any worship that issues from the individual will be tainted with ingratitude, jealousy and spite! The ungrateful heart can never worship in a way that brings down the

presence of the Lord.

Zig Ziglar said, we need to “*Get a check up, form the neck up – Eliminate some stinking thinking and get an attitude adjustment!*”

After all, the reason we are worshipping is to engage the presence of the King, is it not?

“God inhabits the praises of His people.”